

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF
MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SATURDAY 12 SEPTEMBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



THE HUNDREDTH EDITION: A WEEKEND BUILT ON THE THINGS THAT KEEP — THE DRAM, THE PLATE, THE MOUNTAIN YOU GO BACK TO — WHILE A SECOND OIL GATE FALLS AND MONEY TURNS DEAR

THE GRAND TOUR

Hakone and the Fuji Five Lakes — onsen, world-class art, and the mountain that hides from anyone who came for the postcard

THE RABBIT HOLE

Down the dram: inside single malt's crash, its casks, and the investment scam waiting at the bottom of the glass

THE GOOD LIFE

Grand Seiko puts a watch that loses twenty seconds a year into everyday steel

THIS ISSUE • THE WEEKEND BOOK • NO. 100

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FROM THE DESK

“Have nothing in your houses that you do not know to be useful, or believe to be beautiful.”

William Morris, “The Beauty of Life,” 1880

A hundredth issue lands on a weekend, so we let the book keep its own counsel: the plate that outlives the pattern, the dram worth ageing, the mountain you return to. Morris’s test — useful, or beautiful, nothing else — is the buy-once creed a century early, and the quiet answer to a week spent pricing scarcity.

THE STRIP • AT FRIDAY’S CLOSE

Brent crude	\$109.98	▲ +13% wk
Gold (spot /oz)	\$4,335	▲ firm
Bitcoin	\$77,000	▼ risk-off
VWRA (All-World)	~\$195	▲ near high
US 10-year	4.96%	▲ cusp of 5%
DXY (dollar)	99.11	▲ bid
USD/JPY	154.2	▲ BoJ wk
STI	5,807	▲ record

Levels near the 11 Sep close; VWRA ~195 read 6 Sep, BNDW bond proxy ~\$69 (held). Not advice — see **p14**.

THE SCOREBOARD • SATURDAY — WHERE WE KEEP SCORE ON OURSELVES

- ✓ **“The ECB hikes to 2.50% on 10 Sep.” (No. 98)** — Right; 25bp, unanimous, the second hike in three months.
- ✓ **“US August CPI near consensus — 0.4% m/m, 3.4% headline, 2.4% core.” (No. 98/99)** — Right, to the decimal.
- **“August payrolls are the swing factor; consensus ~55k.” (No. 90)** — Push. They were the swing factor — but the print crushed the call at +162k. We had the setup, not the size.
- **“Venice’s Lion does NOT go to McDonagh’s ‘Wild Horse Nine.’” (No. 98)** — Open; the jury sits tonight, graded next Saturday (**p11**).

✓ right • ● push • ○ open. Also right, unshown: Canada’s 8 Sep tariffs (80–84); no Western wire scooped our Undercurrents (71/72/74/79); the Sennheiser TW5 ship (79); the SGX MediaTek listing (94/95); Enhypen’s No. 1 (92). A green week; the asterisk is the payrolls size and a Lion not yet awarded. Ledger: state/predictions.json.

SOURCES Scoreboard graded against the desks that made each call; market levels TradingEconomics, CNBC, Rigzone, Investing.com near the 11 Sep close. CPI: BLS/CNBC (11 Sep). Payrolls: BLS/CNBC (4 Sep). Tariffs: Canada.ca/CNBC. Convertible: TrendForce/Newsquawk. Enhypen: Billboard.

IRAN & THE GULF · THE SECOND GATE CLOSSES

The Houthis take Perim, and the war owns both doors to the oil

The seizure of a small island in the middle of Bab el-Mandeb this week completed a takeover of Yemen's Red Sea coast — handing Iran's allies a grip on a second chokepoint while Hormuz stays a shooting war, and driving Brent to a hundred and ten dollars.

The map of the war closed a little further on Thursday. A day after taking the port of Mocha, Yemen's Houthis seized Perim — the island that sits in the throat of the Bab el-Mandeb strait — giving the group effective command of the narrow gate between the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden through which much of the Suez-bound oil trade must pass.¹ With Mocha and the coast behind them, Iran's allies now sit astride a second oil chokepoint, on the opposite flank of the Arabian Peninsula from the Strait of Hormuz this desk has tracked since February.¹

It is a pincer. Hormuz, at the mouth of the Gulf, stayed a combat zone this week — renewed US-Iran naval clashes, the same disruption that has kept roughly a fifth of seaborne oil under threat since the February strikes.² Now Bab el-Mandeb, at the mouth of the Red Sea, is contested too. Between them, Iran's proxies have a hand on both the doors through which the Gulf's crude reaches the world, and the 2022 truce that ended the last phase of the Yemen war looks close to collapse.¹

The price did the talking. Brent ran to about a hundred and nine dollars and ninety-eight cents on Friday — up some six per cent overnight and roughly thirteen on the week, its highest since May — after strikes inside Saudi Arabia forced the shutdown of a critical oil pipeline, which Riyadh's energy ministry confirmed.² Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, by one account, pressed President Trump privately for direct American military intervention; the appeal is single-sourced and logged as such.³

\$109.98

BRENT CRUDE, FRI 11 SEP — A FOUR-MONTH HIGH, AND ROUGHLY SEVEN TO EIGHT DOLLARS OF IT IS NOW PURE WAR-RISK INSURANCE

TEL AVIV

TIMES OF ISRAEL

Reads the week as Iran's proxies "completing the takeover" of the vital Bab al-Mandab lane — a pincer that, for this outlet, vindicates the strikes on Iran and leaves the Islamic Republic astride chokepoints on both flanks of Arabia. The threat is framed as structural, not passing.

DOHA

AL JAZEERA

Frames the crisis as blowback from the US-Israel war on Iran: the attacks "dent hopes" for a Hormuz reopening because Iranian demands cloud the outlook. The strait stays shut until the underlying war is settled — not bombed — and escalation has no political off-ramp.

THE CHATTER

Shipping desks say the market is repricing the *duration* of the risk, not just the escalation. The concrete number is in the insurance: war-risk premiums now run seven-and-a-half to twelve-and-a-half per cent of a hull's value per transit, against roughly a quarter of a per cent before the war — and marine war-risk claims have already topped two billion dollars.²

gCaptain; Rigzone; CNBC (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The oil bulls are fighting the tape. OPEC has just cut its 2026 demand-growth forecast for a fifth straight month, to 380,000 barrels a day; the IEA now sees demand actually contracting into a surplus above two million barrels. J.P. Morgan still models Brent averaging around seventy-eight dollars by year-end, Goldman near eighty in the fourth quarter. Strip the war premium and the fundamentals point to the low eighties. The concession they make: OPEC's spare capacity has shrunk to about two-and-a-half million barrels — a thin buffer if a real barrel is actually lost.³

SOURCES 1 — NBC News, Times of Israel, CNBC (10–11 Sep 2026) — Houthis seize Mocha (10 Sep) and Perim island (11 Sep), completing the Bab el-Mandeb takeover; 2022 Yemen truce in doubt. 2 — Rigzone, The National, CNBC, gCaptain (10–11 Sep) — Brent ~\$109.98 (+~6% o/n, +~13% wk); Saudi pipeline shut after strikes (Saudi energy ministry); renewed US-Iran Hormuz clashes; war-risk premiums 7.5–12.5% of hull vs ~0.25% pre-war; marine claims >\$2bn. 3 — NBC News (single-sourced, the private Mbs appeal); OilPrice/OPEC-IEA, ING, J.P. Morgan, Goldman via OilPrice — OPEC 2026 demand +380kb/d (5th cut), IEA surplus >2mb/d, Brent forecasts ~\$78–80, spare capacity ~2.5mb/d. Wording to confirm against live articles.

UKRAINE · THE PAUSE THAT LAPSED

A three-day quiet ends, and the drones come back to Kyiv

The short halt tied to the Witkoff–Kushner shuttle expired on 8 September; Russia struck the capital within the day and again overnight, and Moscow held to its maximal terms.

The breathing space is over. The three-day pause on strikes at the capitals — the thin yield of the early-September shuttle between Moscow and Kyiv — lapsed on 8 September, and Russian jet-powered drones hit Kyiv again: a gas station and the Holosiivskyi district, four injured, then a residential block overnight on the 11th with at least eight more.¹ President Zelensky warned that ballistic salvos are straining Ukraine’s air defences; President Putin restated the demand that has frozen every round — no front-line ceasefire, the “root causes” first, Ukrainian withdrawal from the whole of Donetsk.¹ Talks are stalled, not dead.

A pause is not a peace. It is a breath between barrages.

Elsewhere the map stayed busy. In Nepal, the young government of Prime Minister Balen Shah — the former Kathmandu mayor elected in the spring — met its first true emergency as catastrophic August floods knocked out hydropower and left a toll running into the thousands; the prime minister’s relief fund had gathered some twelve-and-a-half billion rupees by the 10th, with China sending fifty tonnes of supplies and two million dollars.² It is the first hard test of a government that rode discontent into office and must now answer for the water.²

THE SCEPTIC

Diplomatic tempo is not diplomatic progress. Two envoys and a seventy-two-hour lull produced no framework, no monitoring, no exchange — and the resumption was immediate. Read the shuttle as a marker laid down for later, not a thaw.

ALSO ON THE WIRE

Xi to Washington, 24 September. China’s leader will make a state visit later this month, with artificial-intelligence governance topping the agenda and a large business delegation in tow — the diplomatic set-piece the autumn’s tech-and-trade stories keep pointing toward.³

The oil war’s quiet victims. The chokepoint fight is a Red Sea insurance story before it is a shortage: hulls reroute, premiums climb, and the barrels still mostly move — the cost lands on freight and cover, not yet on the pump in a way the fundamentals justify (p14).

The Saudi pipeline, the escalation lever. The strike that forced a critical Saudi pipeline offline is the detail that could turn an insurance story into a shortage one — and the reason the Crown Prince’s reported private plea for American intervention (p3) is the week’s real risk, not the shipping headlines.

THE CHATTER

The prediction-market crowd is still fading the escalation: contracts on a Yemen-truce collapse and a wider Gulf war have moved, but the base case traders price remains “contained, expensive, and unresolved” rather than all-out regional war — the same read that has paid all year.³

prediction markets; analyst notes (as reported)

For a Singapore reader the through-line is the one on the money pages, not the war maps. Two contested chokepoints, an oil price that carries a seven-to-eight-dollar fear premium, and three central banks tightening into it is a portfolio story before it is a geopolitical one — which is where this edition takes it next, on The Macro Desk.³

SOURCES 1 — Kyiv Independent, Kyiv Post (10–11 Sep 2026) — 5–8 Sep pause lapses; Kyiv strikes (Holosiivskyi, 4 injured; residential block, ≥8); Zelensky on air-defence strain; Putin’s Donetsk demand. 2 — nepalnews, AP (8–10 Sep) — PM Balen Shah; August flood toll into the thousands; relief fund –Rs 12.6bn by 10 Sep; 901 MW hydropower lost; China 50 tonnes + US\$2m. 3 — US News, CNBC (Jul–Sep) — Xi US state visit 24 Sep, AI on the agenda; prediction-market positioning as reported. Toll figures are event tallies and may be revised.

THE HAZE · WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOUR WEEKEND

The air turns “unhealthy” for the first time since 2023 — and may not clear for weeks

Transboundary smoke pushed the central region’s PSI past a hundred this week, the first haze-driven “unhealthy” reading in nearly two years; with below-normal rain forecast into October, plan the outdoor hours around the dashboard, not the calendar.

The smell came back before the number did. By 11 September the twenty-four-hour PSI had climbed into the moderate-to-low-unhealthy band, with the central region pushing past a hundred — the first time Singapore’s air has reached the “unhealthy” zone from haze since October 2023.¹ The source is familiar: fires in Sumatra and Kalimantan, carried on southerly and south-easterly winds, with the central readings peaking around a hundred and five earlier in the month.¹

The reader’s practical question is how long. The forecast answer is unwelcome: below-normal rainfall is expected through October, so unless the wind turns, the haze can settle in for weeks rather than days.¹ That shifts the weekend calculus — N95s back within reach, the air purifier on overnight, and the outdoor run, the football, the elderly and the children’s plans checked against the hourly reading rather than assumed. This is a manage-it, not a wait-it-out, week.

PSI 100+

CENTRAL REGION, 11 SEP — THE FIRST HAZE-DRIVEN “UNHEALTHY” BAND SINCE OCTOBER 2023

THE CHATTER

The resident read, as it always is at the first whiff: the purifier-and-mask drills come out, the parents’ chats trade PSI screenshots by the hour, and the standing grievance — that the smoke is imported and the fix is not ours to make — resurfaces. The practical consensus is unglamorous: watch the one-hour PM2.5, not the headline PSI, when deciding whether the kids train.¹

NEA advisories; parent forums (as reported)

GOVERNANCE · THE PAY DEBATE, THE DELTA

The House backs the rise, and argues about the receipt

Parliament debated the political-salary revision on 10 September, and the surprise was how little the money itself was contested. The prime minister’s salary rises to about S\$3.6m and an entry-grade minister’s toward S\$1.8m, against a 2025 median monthly income of S\$5,775; the MP allowance climbs from S\$192,500 to S\$259,000, with the one-off ministerial increase capped at nine per cent.² The Workers’ Party’s Pritam Singh backed the MP rise “in view of inflation” — and then pressed where it stings: full transparency on an entry minister’s total remuneration, and a blunt question about whether high pay actually pulls private-sector talent in, when “only a small handful” of the Cabinet came from it.² The fight, in other words, moved from the number to the disclosure.

THE SCEPTIC

Transparency is the cheap ask that changes little. Publishing an entry minister’s full package answers a fairness question without touching the formula that sets it — and the talent claim cuts both ways: if the private-sector pipeline is really “a small handful,” the pay may be buying retention and probity, not the outside stars it is sold as. A number defended on one rationale and justified by another is the thing to watch.

IN BRIEF

The data desk waits. August CPI and August NODX were not yet out as of the 12th; the latest official prints stand at July CPI +2.2% headline (+2.0% core) and July NODX +24.2% year on year. We hold the August numbers rather than guess them (p14).²

The PSLE fortnight. Written papers fall in the last week of September — the household’s real calendar this month, and the reason the sleep science on p12 is timed the way it is.

SOURCES 1 — AsiaOne, Batam News (11 Sep 2026) — PSI moderate-low-unhealthy, central >100, first haze “unhealthy” since Oct 2023; central ~105 on 4 Sep; Sumatra/Kalimantan fires; below-normal rain through October. 2 — The Star, SCMP, NST (9–10 Sep) — PM to S\$3.6m, entry minister ~\$1.8m, median \$5,775, MP allowance S\$192,500 – 259,000, one-off ≤9%; Pritam Singh backs MP rise, presses total-remuneration transparency and the talent question; July CPI +2.2%/+2.0%, July NODX +24.2% (August not yet released). Peak PSI for the 11th not confirmed to a single reading; August prints held.

BUY IT ONCE • THE EVERYDAY TABLE

The plate that outlives the pattern

Dinnerware sorts almost entirely by one hidden number — how far the clay vitrified. Learn that, and you can judge any plate in the shop cold, spot the Staffordshire name hiding an Indonesian body, and see why the entry tier already wins.

Pick up a plate and you are really asking one question: how far did the fire go? A ceramic body is clay, a flux and a filler heated until the flux melts into glass that fills the pores and locks the grains — the more complete that **vitrification**, the denser, stronger and more chip-resistant the plate.¹ That is the whole ladder. **Earthenware** fires low and never fully vitrifies — porous, glaze-dependent, first to chip; the disposable tier to skip, and the one many celebrity lines quietly use while charging bone-china money. **Stoneware** fires hotter to near-full vitrification: dense, tough, the honest everyday sweet spot. **Porcelain** fires hottest — thin-walled yet the most chip- and scratch-resistant. **Bone china**, the English trick of roughly half bone ash, vitrifies lower yet comes out strongest and most translucent: the delicate-looking body that is hardest to chip.¹

The tells are in your hand: a smooth-ground footring, a rolled rim (thin sharp rims chip first), dense-for-size weight, an even glaze with no crazing. The biggest longevity trap in “fine” lines is metallic trim — gold and platinum aren’t microwave-safe and abrade in the wash.¹ The durability trump card is hotelware: **Steelite** adds alumina and rolls the rim — its Distinction range carries a lifetime edge-chip warranty.²

~90%

OF THE DURABILITY, FOR ~10% OF THE GRAIL PRICE — VITRIFICATION MAXES OUT AT THE ENTRY-OF-QUALITY TIER

So the tiers, for a buy-once table. **Entry-of-quality:** Villeroy & Boch’s vitrified NewWave (~US\$33 a plate), Denby stoneware (US\$35–76, ten-year guarantee), IKEA’s FÄRGKLAR set (~US\$49), Corelle’s tough Vitrelle — this tier already survives daily life.² **The sweet spot:** Heath Ceramics, Jono Pandolfi (a four-piece setting ~US\$195), Iittala Teema, and the reader’s Japan pick — Hasami, Arita and Mino open stock, US\$15–60 a piece. **The grail:** Astier de Villatte (US\$90–171), Ginori 1735, Feldspar bone china, and Hermès — the logo-tax test case.²

THE CHATTER • THE WHITE-LABEL TRUTH

What the boards teach: buy open-stock so one breakage isn’t a new set — Replacements, Ltd. exists because patterns get retired. And know who made it. **Wedgwood** trades on “English bone china” while most production moved to Indonesia; **Royal Copenhagen** Blue Fluted is made in Thailand; **Narumi** of Japan is the unbadged bone-china body behind many luxury-hotel services. Singapore’s own Supermama plates are made by Kihara in Arita — a Japanese product, honestly.³ **r/BuyItForLife, Modern Japan Crafts, maker filings (as reported)**

The Singapore reality is easy. Takashimaya carries the broadest range; Tangs and ToTT cover entry-to-mid; Supermama is the design-meets-Arita pick; and the Japan-import specialists — Musubi Kiln, Akazuki, Mogutable — ship Hasami and Mino open stock to your door. Stack with felt separators; footring-on-glaze is the real domestic killer.³

THE SCEPTIC

Where the pricing is theatre. The clearest tell, per the trade: a celebrity line in basic earthenware priced like bone china is selling branding, not craft. Heritage names charge a Staffordshire or Copenhagen story for an Asian-factory body; Hermès asks US\$165-plus for porcelain no better than good vitrified ware. Hand-painting is real labour, but its marginal durability over a US\$35 plate is essentially zero. Buy the material and the footring; skip the surname.³

THE ATELIER

VITRIFY

OPEN STOCK

BUY THE MAKER

NEXT ON THE BENCH • VOTE THE DESK’S NEXT CATEGORY

Copper & stainless cookware — clad vs solid copper, and the foundries behind the famous names.

Glassware & stemware — Duralex durability to Zalto’s grail; machine vs mouth-blown.

Coffee grinders — burr geometry as the whole game, and why the grind is most of the cup.

SOURCES 1 — WebstaurantStore, Digitalfire, ResearchGate (bone-ash study), Malacasa journal — vitrification; earthenware/stoneware/porcelain/bone-china bodies and firing; quality tells; metallic-trim caveat. 2 — us.steelite.com; Villeroy & Boch; Denby; IKEA; Heath Ceramics; DWR/Jono Pandolfi; Iittala; Musubi Kiln/Akazuki (Hasami/Arita/Kaneko Kohyo); Astier de Villatte; Ginori 1735; Feldspar; Marie Daäge; Hermès — makers and current prices. 3 — r/BuyItForLife, Replacements Ltd., Modern Japan Crafts, manufacturing.net (Wedgwood — Indonesia), Royal Copenhagen listings (Thailand), narumi.co.jp, Supermama/Kihara; Takashimaya, Tangs, ToTT — white-label truths, open-stock counsel, SG stockists. Prices convert/verify at point of sale.

AI & CAPITAL · THE DELTA

DeepSeek picks Shanghai, and keeps the crown jewel at home

The lab we flagged as filing to list has now chosen where: it has hired CITIC Securities for a Shanghai STAR Market IPO rather than Hong Kong — a home-team decision that lands two weeks before Xi flies to Washington to talk AI.

The news since last edition is the venue. DeepSeek has engaged CITIC Securities for pre-listing tutoring on Shanghai's STAR Market, aiming to begin the process this year — and the choice is the story.¹ Its peers went the other way: Zhipu and MiniMax listed in Hong Kong this year and Moonshot filed there this month. DeepSeek staying onshore reads as alignment with Beijing's push to raise capital at home, and the timing is not lost on anyone — it lands just before Xi Jinping's 24 September state visit, with AI atop the agenda (p4).¹

The valuation ladder is steep and a little blurred. The lab raised about US\$7.4bn in June at more than US\$50bn; a fresh pre-IPO round has been reported targeting roughly US\$74–75bn.¹ Treat it as a range, not a point — the figure that matters is that a company famous for giving its models away is about to ask the public markets to price it, and has picked the market that answers to Beijing to do it.¹

~\$75bn

THE PRE-IPO VALUATION REPORTED FOR DEEPSEEK — UP FROM ~\$50BN AT JUNE'S RAISE

THE CHATTER

The trade-press frame is the “great Chinese AI IPO rush” — a wave of labs racing to list before the window narrows, with DeepSeek the marquee name that chose the mainland over Hong Kong. The read on desks: the listing venue is a sovereignty signal as much as a funding event.¹

Reuters, Fortune, Qz (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

What are the public actually pricing? DeepSeek has prioritised research and open weights over a commercial product, so its revenue model is the open question institutions keep raising; add founder-control governance and semiconductor export-control exposure. A ~US\$75bn tag on a lab whose signature move is to make its work free is a bet on strategic value, not a cash-flow multiple — and those are the ones that re-rate hardest.²

ALSO ON THE DESK

The shadow over the story. Researchers reported in late August that Chinese hackers are using DeepSeek's own models to sharpen attacks — the security cycle's counterweight to the IPO narrative, and a reminder that an open, capable model is dual-use by default.²

The rest of the rush. DeepSeek is the marquee name, but Zhipu and MiniMax have already listed in Hong Kong this year and Moonshot filed there this month — the “great Chinese AI IPO rush” is a wave, and the venue each lab picks is a reading of which way Beijing's wind blows.¹

The home-lab reader has a stake in all of it, because these are the labs whose open weights land on his rig (p8). A DeepSeek that answers to the public markets, and to Beijing, is a different kind of open-source patron than the research shop that gave its models away — and the terms of the next release are the thing to watch, not the valuation.²

SOURCES 1 — Reuters (exclusive, 9 Sep 2026), Seoul Economic Daily, Qz, Fortune, Manila Times — DeepSeek hires CITIC for STAR Market listing this year; peers (Zhipu/MiniMax/Moonshot) in Hong Kong; June raise ~US\$7.4bn at >\$50bn; pre-IPO round ~US\$74–75bn; timing vs Xi 24 Sep. 2 — Yahoo/Reuters, Qz, Bloomberg (24 Aug) — revenue-model and founder-control questions; export-control exposure; report of DeepSeek used to boost cyber-attacks. Valuation printed as a range; wording to confirm against live articles.

THE HOME LAB • WHAT TO RUN THIS FORTNIGHT

The sparse trick that fits a big brain on a small rig

No brand-new open-weight model dropped this week — but the fortnight’s most interesting design is one that lets a hundred-and-twenty-five-billion-parameter model run on hardware that could never hold it whole.

The home-lab reader keeps asking the wrong question — how many parameters — when the one that matters is how many are active at once. Qwen3.8-Flash-Next, released 26 August, is the fortnight’s clean illustration: a 125-billion-parameter mixture-of-experts model that fires only about six billion per token, paired with a 51-billion-entry n-gram embedding table you can offload to ordinary system RAM.¹ The effect is that a model whose full size would never fit a consumer card runs on one anyway, because the heavy, rarely-touched part sits in cheap memory and only the active experts live on the GPU.¹

For the buy-once rig, the concrete picks. If you want MIT-licensed and precise on VRAM, DeepSeek-V4-Flash (31 July) is 284 billion total, 13 billion active, about 170–175GB — two RTX Pro 6000 Blackwells or a pair of H200s, with a million-token context.¹ If you want the single-card daily driver, the class that still fits one card is the ~30-billion tier, not the frontier: on the current Artificial Analysis index GLM-5.3 leads at 45, Kimi K3 at 44, GLM-5.3-Flash at 42 — but that Flash still wants roughly 306GB in FP8, Hopper-class iron, not a desktop.² The lesson the sparse designs teach is that “runs at home” is now an architecture choice, not just a spec sheet.

6B of 125B

ACTIVE PARAMETERS PER TOKEN IN QWEN3.8-FLASH-NEXT — THE REASON IT FITS WHERE ITS SIZE SAYS IT CAN’T

THE CHATTER

The local-LLM boards’ running counsel this cycle: stop chasing the top of the leaderboard onto hardware you don’t own, and learn the offload tricks — MoE routing plus an embedding table in system RAM is what turns a “datacentre” model into a weekend build. The frontier is for renting; the ~30B card-fillers are for owning.²

local-LLM communities; Artificial Analysis (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Sparse is not free. A 125B model with 6B active still needs the whole weight set *somewhere* fast enough, and offloading to system RAM buys capacity at the cost of tokens-per-second — fine for a batch job overnight, painful in a live chat. Benchmark index points don’t capture the latency you actually feel. Run the model you can serve at the speed you’ll tolerate, not the one that tops a chart you’ll never fit.

~306GB

FP8 MEMORY GLM-5.3-FLASH WANTS — HOPPER-CLASS IRON, NOT A SINGLE DESKTOP CARD

THE BUY-ONCE RIG, THIS FORTNIGHT

The single-card daily driver. A ~30-billion-parameter model at a four-bit quant fits one high-end consumer card with room for context — the class the reader actually runs, and where the GLM and Qwen “Flash” smaller siblings live.²

The two-card frontier. DeepSeek-V4-Flash at ~170–175GB is the MIT-licensed pick if you have a pair of workstation Blackwells or H200s and want a million-token window — the home lab’s upper bound before you are renting datacentre time.¹

The DDR5 tax, still biting. The memory-price spike that makes “offload to system RAM” less free than it sounds is the same one squeezing every home build this quarter — a reason the sparse-model trick is cleverness under constraint, not a free lunch.²

The through-line for a buy-once builder: the sensible spend this fortnight is not the frontier weight but the card and the fast RAM that let a sparse ~30B model serve you at a speed you’ll actually use, with a two-card path held in reserve for the day a V4-Flash-class model earns its place.²

SOURCES 1 — IntuitionLabs, benchlm (Qwen3.8-Flash-Next, 26 Aug 2026 — 125B MoE / ~6B active + 51B n-gram table offloadable); Open Source For You, morphllm (DeepSeek-V4-Flash, 31 Jul, MIT, 284B/13B active, ~170–175GB, 1M context). 2 — wavect open-weight comparison; Artificial Analysis Index (as of 8 Sep) — GLM-5.3 45, Kimi K3 44, GLM-5.3-Flash 42 (~306GB FP8), Qwen3.8 40, DeepSeek V4 Pro 36; DDR5 pricing thread. Specs as reported; verify VRAM against your quantisation.

GEAR WE'RE WATCHING · THE HEADPHONE THAT PHONES HOME

Sonos builds a headphone that steals the music off your speakers

The Ace Ultra ships this month at US\$449 with twice the noise-cancelling and a genuinely new trick — press a button and the audio playing on your Sonos system hands straight to your ears over Wi-Fi. For a reader with the speakers already, that's the hook; the ecosystem is also the catch.

Sonos's second headphone is its first interesting one. The Ace Ultra, unveiled at IFA in Berlin and shipping on 29 September at US\$449, brings a redesigned forty-millimetre driver, adaptive noise-cancelling the company rates at twice as effective, ten microphones, Bluetooth 6.0, thirty-five hours with ANC on, and a fast charge that buys three hours from three minutes.¹ The feature that matters, though, is Headphone Linking: with a Sonos system in the house, the audio playing on your speakers moves directly to the Ace Ultra over Wi-Fi — you walk out of the room and the film or the record comes with you, no re-pairing.¹

For this reader that is the whole pitch. If the speakers are already Sonos, the Ace Ultra is the piece that lets the same audio follow you off the sofa — a genuinely useful bit of ecosystem plumbing rather than a spec-sheet number. And it undercuts the original Ace: more headphone, less money.¹

US\$449

THE ACE ULTRA — CHEAPER THAN THE FIRST ACE, WITH 2× THE ANC AND WI-FI AUDIO HAND-OFF

THE CHATTER

The hands-on verdicts (What Hi-Fi and the rest) read the Ace Ultra as the headphone the first Ace should have been — the ANC and the Wi-Fi linking are the wins — while the forums are warier, still scarred by the 2024 app meltdown and asking the obvious question: does the software hold up this time. The tempering note is that the best features only exist if you live in the Sonos world.²

What Hi-Fi hands-on; r/sonos, r/headphones (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The trick is the trap. Headphone Linking is lovely and it is a leash — it only works inside a Sonos system, so the Ace Ultra's best reason to exist is also the reason it deepens the lock-in. As a plain Bluetooth headphone at US\$449 it is good, not class-leading; Sony's and Bose's flagships still edge the ANC and the folding travel case. And Sonos's software reliability is a live question, not a settled one. Buy it because you are already in the ecosystem and want it to reach your ears — not to escape a Sony.²

STILL ON THE SHELF

Beam Ultra, the other half. Sonos's compact soundbar also stepped up — US\$699, true 7.1.2 Atmos, nine drivers, shipping 29 Sep — the smart-home reader's Atmos pick between the Beam and the Arc Ultra; a watch-list until the reviews land.¹

Sennheiser's bud, now shipping. The MOMENTUM True Wireless 5 (US\$299.95, its user-replaceable batteries the buy-once story) began shipping 3 September as we called (p2) — a one-line delta, not a re-run.

SOURCES 1 — What Hi-Fi, SoundGuys, ecoustics, Engadget, Gearbrain (Aug–Sep 2026) — Sonos Ace Ultra unveiled at IFA, ships 29 Sep, US\$449 (£399/€449); 40mm driver, 2× adaptive ANC, 10 mics, BT 6.0, 35h ANC, 3-min/3-hr fast charge, Headphone Linking over Wi-Fi; Beam Ultra US\$699, true 7.1.2 Atmos, nine drivers, 29 Sep. 2 — What Hi-Fi hands-on; r/sonos, r/headphones (as reported) — app-reliability scepticism; Sony/Bose ANC comparison. Product image representative (see attestation); community sentiment attributed, verify against live threads.

OBJECTS & ESCAPES · THE EVERYDAY GRAIL

Twenty seconds a year, now in a watch you'd actually wear daily

Grand Seiko has moved its ±20-seconds-a-year Spring Drive “Ultra Fine Accuracy” movement out of precious metal and into everyday steel — the accuracy earns the ticket; the price ladder is the argument.

The number is the point. Grand Seiko's Caliber 9RB2 is rated to twenty seconds a year — the tolerance that earns the “Ultra Fine Accuracy” name, an order of magnitude beyond the chronometer standard a fine mechanical watch is held to.¹ Until now it lived only in precious-metal cases; from September 2026 five Spring Drive U.F.A. references reach boutiques worldwide with the movement in Ever-Brilliant Steel at about US\$10,200, and High-Intensity Titanium at US\$11,400.¹ The new steel pieces — the SLGB011 “Atera Valley,” the 40mm SLGB013 “Lake Suwa,” the 37mm SLGB015 — build on last year's limited SLGB005 “Ice Forest,” and turn a display-case marvel into a watch you could wear to the office without insuring your wrist.¹

For the reader who buys movements, not logos, this is Grand Seiko's pitch at its clearest: the thing you are paying for is engineering you can measure, in a case metal that shrugs off daily life. The dials keep the brand's nature-study finish; the accuracy keeps the receipts.¹

±20 s/yr

CALIBER 9RB2 — ROUGHLY AN ORDER BEYOND A MECHANICAL CHRONOMETER'S DAILY TOLERANCE

THE CHATTER

The enthusiast read splits, as it always does with Spring Drive: one camp calls the U.F.A. the most honest luxury watch going — you pay for accuracy and finishing, not a marketing story — while another shrugs that a quartz-regulated movement, however beautiful, is a hard sell at ten thousand dollars to anyone who wants a beating balance. The steel release is read as Grand Seiko widening the door.²

watch forums, enthusiast press (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Ask what the accuracy is worth to you. A Spring Drive is quartz-regulated at heart; a purist paying US\$10k-plus can have a COSC or METAS mechanical with a balance wheel he can feel, or a US\$300 quartz that keeps time just as well on paper. And Grand Seiko's steel pricing has climbed steadily — the “value” case that built the brand's cult is thinner each year. The movement genuinely earns admiration; whether it earns the cheque depends on whether accuracy, not romance, is what you buy a watch for.²

STILL COMING

TAG Heuer Monaco Speed 12. A twelve-cylinder piston hour display, titanium, US\$87,000, limited to fifty — but it debuted at the Monaco GP in June and only ships in December, so it's a note, not news. A curiosity for the horology desk to watch, not a buy for the reader who reads this desk for value.²

SOURCES 1 — SJX Watches, WatchTime, Grand Seiko Boutique, monochrome-watches (Sep 2026) — Spring Drive U.F.A. Caliber 9RB2 (±20 s/yr); five refs from Sep 2026; Ever-Brilliant Steel ~US\$10,200 / High-Intensity Titanium ~US\$11,400; SLGB011 “Atera Valley,” SLGB013 “Lake Suwa” (40mm), SLGB015 (37mm); builds on SLGB005 “Ice Forest.” 2 — watch forums/enthusiast press (as reported); Robb Report (TAG Heuer Monaco Speed 12, US\$87,000 / CHF 70,000, 40mm Ti, ltd 50, ships Dec). Hero image representative (see attestation); prices verify at boutique.

VENICE · THE LION, TONIGHT

A jury sits in Venice, and the frontrunner has a fourteen-minute ovation behind him

The Golden Lion is decided tonight under Maggie Gyllenhaal's jury; Martin McDonagh's "Wild Horse Nine" is the surest bet on the board — which is exactly why our own sceptic bet against it.

By the time most readers open this, the eighty-third Venice Film Festival will have handed out its Golden Lion — the ceremony runs Saturday night on the Lido, hours after this book reaches the dashboard.¹ The frontrunner is not in doubt: Martin McDonagh's "Wild Horse Nine," which premiered on 3 September to a fourteen-minute standing ovation, ninety-one per cent on Rotten Tomatoes and a Metacritic of eighty-one, and which a jury that rewarded McDonagh's writing here in 2017 and 2022 seems built to love.¹ George Clooney and Ellen Burstyn take lifetime Golden Lions; Clooney's own "Jay Kelly" played out of the top-prize race.¹

We flagged the contrarian call two editions ago — that ovation length is a weak predictor and the Lion would not go to McDonagh — and we'll grade it, win or lose, next Saturday (p2). The point of a scoreboard is that you don't get to quietly drop the bet you talked yourself into.¹

14 min

THE STANDING OVATION FOR "WILD HORSE NINE" — THE NUMBER THE WHOLE RACE IS NOW MEASURED AGAINST

THE CHATTER

The festival-floor consensus, per the trade coverage, is that the ovation "reframed the whole race" and made McDonagh the one to beat. Prediction markets are less sure, flagging a late surge for a couple of rivals — the gap between the room's applause and the jury's taste is the whole suspense.²

Martin Cid; prediction markets (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Not everyone stood. IndieWire's David Ehrlich gave "Wild Horse Nine" a B-minus — "prickly but unconvincing" — and Venice juries have a long habit of handing the Lion to the film the Lido applauded second-loudest. A fourteen-minute ovation measures a room's mood at midnight, not a jury's vote a week later. That's the whole basis of the bet.²

NEW MUSIC FRIDAY · THE COMEBACKS

The week's records reward the returning. Bloc Party are back with "Anatomy of a Brief Romance," a comeback LP that leans into the confessional; Ezra Collective's "Here Because of Hope" follows their Top-Ten breakthrough with the same jubilant London jazz.³ Around them a busy Friday — new Sylvan Esso, David Guetta, Kings of Leon, Slipknot — but the two worth the weekend's first listen are the ones with something to prove after a long gap.³

IN BRIEF

The box-office backdrop. The summer's tentpole cume still sits near the top of the all-time chart — a reminder that the theatrical business the festivals fret about had its best year in a while, even as the awards machine takes over the calendar.

SOURCES 1 — Martin Cid, Wikipedia (Wild Horse Nine), Variety, GoldDerby (Sep 2026) — Venice Golden Lion ceremony 12 Sep, jury pres. Maggie Gyllenhaal; "Wild Horse Nine" 3 Sep premiere, 14-min ovation, 91% RT (8.6 avg), MC 81; lifetime Lions Clooney & Burstyn; Clooney's "Jay Kelly" out of competition. 2 — IndieWire (Ehrlich, B-), TIME/prediction markets — contested reception; late-surge rivals. 3 — DraftKings New Music Friday, Ghost Cult (11 Sep) — Bloc Party "Anatomy of a Brief Romance," Ezra Collective "Here Because of Hope," plus Sylvan Esso/Guetta/Kings of Leon/Slipknot. Lion result unresolved at press time.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE YEAR THE RULES CHANGED

Age checks arrive just as she reaches the line

Singapore's new social-media age-assurance regime lands squarely on a twelve-year-old — she is just under the under-thirteen threshold now, and crosses it next July. Here is what the law actually does, and what the evidence behind it does and doesn't show.

The household screen conversation just got a statute behind it. At August's National Day Rally the prime minister announced a social-media age-assurance regime, with legislation due early in 2027: six designated services — Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, X, YouTube and HardwareZone — must deploy age checks to stop under-thirteens creating or managing accounts, with default autoplay off and daily time limits for under-eighteens, and the threat that a non-compliant platform could be forced to raise its own minimum age to eighteen.¹ Australia's under-sixteen ban is the regional comparator, still rolling out.¹

For a child born in July 2014 the timing is almost personal. She is twelve — just below the under-thirteen line the law draws now — and she crosses it next summer, so the rule reframes exactly her cohort's first proper accounts. The question a parent should ask is not whether the rule is well-meant but what the evidence under it actually says.¹

The best recent read is careful. A 2026 paper in the Nature-portfolio journal *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications*, drawing on a US survey of 50,231 children aged six to seventeen — a band that squarely contains a twelve-year-old — found higher screen time associated with anxiety, depression,

conduct problems and attention difficulties, but with physical activity, sleep duration and bedtime regularity acting as parallel mediators.² In plain terms: the plausible harm runs *through* lost sleep and lost movement, which are the two levers a parent can actually pull — especially in the fortnight before a major exam.²

50,231

CHILDREN AGED 6–17 IN THE 2026 STUDY — THE HARM RAN THROUGH LOST SLEEP AND MOVEMENT, THE LEVERS YOU CAN PULL

THE CHATTER

Among Singapore parents the announcement drew a familiar split — relief that someone drew a line, and immediate scepticism about the mechanics: how, exactly, will a platform verify a child's age without a facial scan or an ID upload the same parents distrust? The practical worry has moved from “should there be a rule” to “what will it cost us in data to enforce one.”¹

MDDI consultation coverage; parent reaction (as reported)

Treat the desk's counsel as general guidance, not medical advice: the law is a floor, not a parenting plan. The evidence points at sleep and activity, so those are where a household's own rules earn their keep — the subject of the facing page.

SOURCES 1 — AsiaOne, TechRepublic (Aug–Sep 2026) — NDR 23 Aug age-assurance plan; six designated services; under-13 account bar, autoplay-off, under-18 time limits; legislation early 2027; Australia under-16 comparator. 2 — *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications* (2026), N=50,231 aged 6–17 — screen time associated with anxiety/depression/conduct/ADHD, mediated by activity, sleep duration and bedtime regularity. General guidance, not medical advice.

SLEEP · THE LEVER THAT MATTERS IN EXAM MONTH

Protect the last hour before bed, especially now

The PSLE written papers fall in the last week of September. The freshest sleep research says the pre-bedtime phone is where the damage concentrates — and that the fix is a boundary, not a ban.

If the harm runs through sleep, the hour before bed is the battleground. A July 2026 study of pre-bedtime social-media use found that longer use was associated with reduced sleep efficiency, a trend to shorter sleep, and more awakenings and fragmentation — the effect notably worse on weekends.¹ It sits on top of a Swedish cohort of twelve-to-sixteen-year-olds showing screens displacing sleep through the familiar pathways, and a public-health guide of under two hours a day for six-to-twelves.¹ The exam-month takeaway is unglamorous and specific: guard the last hour, charge the phone outside the bedroom, and hold the weekend wake time close to the weekday one.¹

The rule that works isn't "no phone." It's "not in the last hour, and not in the bedroom."

And then the corrective, because a family desk that only amplifies alarm is doing its reader a disservice. The strongest sceptics here are not cranks but the field's own methodologists, and their case is that the screens-cause-harm link is real but small, and easily swamped by things that matter more — family stress, sleep, offline friendships.²

THE SCEPTIC · AGAINST THE PANIC

Candice Odgers of UC Irvine argues the screen-time-to-harm link is "small, inconsistent and easily overshadowed" by other factors, and that over-focusing on it distracts from the real drivers of youth distress. Orben and Przybylski's specification-curve work — across roughly 355,000 adolescents — puts digital technology's share of the variance in wellbeing at about four-tenths of one per cent, "comparable to wearing glasses." Przybylski's line on the panic literature: "extraordinary claims require extraordinary evidence."²

Hold both truths, then. The age-assurance law and a sensible sleep boundary are reasonable; the doom framing is not supported by the strongest evidence. For a twelve-year-old in her PSLE fortnight, the move that the research actually backs is dull and effective — protect the sleep, keep the movement, and let the rest be a boundary rather than a battle. General guidance, not medical advice.²

There is a quieter reason the Australian comparator matters here. Its under-sixteen ban is being watched precisely because it tests whether a hard age line does more than a household boundary — and the early signal, still leaking out, is that enforcement is the hard part, not the principle.² Singapore's age-assurance route (p12) bets on verification-at-the-platform instead of an outright ban; which approach travels better is the policy question the next year will answer, and the reason a parent should treat the coming law as a backstop, not a substitute for the rules at home.²

WHAT THE EVIDENCE ACTUALLY BACKS

Protect the sleep window. Charge the phone outside the bedroom and hold the last hour clear — the pathway with the strongest evidence, and the one most in a parent's control.¹

Keep the movement. The other mediator: physical activity. Exam-month is exactly when the training and the walk get cut, and exactly when they matter (p18).¹

Hold the weekend wake time. The sleep damage concentrates on weekends; a stable rise time is worth more than a strict weekday screen rule.¹

PSLE written papers: last week of September. Results around 24–25 November, secondary posting in January. Fix the sleep window now; resist turning a fortnight into a siege.

SOURCES 1 — PubMed 42459127 (Jul 2026, pre-bedtime social-media use & sleep efficiency/fragmentation, weekend effect); Swedish adolescent cohort (ages 12–16, n=4,810); Swedish Public Health Agency (<2h/day, 6–12). 2 — Candice Odgers, UC Irvine (Nov 2025, "is all screen time harmful?"); Orben & Przybylski specification-curve analysis (N=355,000, ~0.4% variance); Australia under-16 ban coverage. General guidance, not medical advice; families with clinical concerns should see a professional.

THE BIG PICTURE • THE PORTFOLIO LENS

One barrel, three central banks, no cushion

A chokepoint war put oil near a hundred and ten; the ECB has hiked, the Fed leans the same way, and the ten-year touched five per cent — so stocks and bonds are falling together again, and the diversification you counted on isn't there.

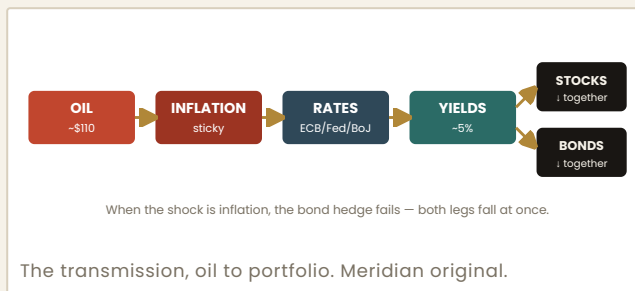
Everything this week ran off the barrel. The Red Sea escalation (p3) pushed Brent toward a hundred and ten, and an oil shock is an inflation shock, so the central banks answered the only way they know: the ECB hiked twenty-five basis points to a 2.50% deposit rate on 10 September — its second in three months — and the Fed, which meets on the fifteenth and sixteenth, has swung from “cutting” to a coin-toss-or-worse on a hike, market-implied odds running from the mid-fifties to two-thirds.¹ The Bank of Japan is expected to move next week too.¹

The transmission is the whole story. Hot oil to sticky inflation to banks tightening into it to yields climbing — the US ten-year touched the cusp of five per cent, a level unseen since 2007, with the thirty-year at a nineteen-year high, JGBs the highest since 1996 and Bunds at a 2011 high.² And here is the part that matters for a diversified portfolio: when yields jump on an inflation scare, bonds sell with equities, not against them. Early September saw exactly that — the global-aggregate sleeve gave no cushion, and the sixty-forty had nowhere to hide.²

THE LEVELS • NEAR THE 11 SEP CLOSE

Brent crude	\$109.98	▲ +13% wk
US 10-year	4.96%	▲ cusp of 5%
DXY (dollar)	99.11	▲ bid
USD/JPY	154.2	▲ BoJ wk
Gold (spot /oz)	\$4,335	▲ hedge bid
Bitcoin	\$77,000	▼ risk-off
VWRA (All-World)	~\$195	▲ near high
STI	5,807	▲ record

VWRA ~195 read 6 Sep; BNDW global-agg proxy ~\$69 (date approx, held). USD/SGD ~1.265 (8 Sep).



4.96%

US 10-YEAR YIELD — ON THE CUSP OF FIVE PER CENT, A 2007 HIGH, AS THE BOND HEDGE QUIETLY FAILED

An inflation shock breaks the one rule the balanced portfolio is built on.

THE CHATTER • THE VERDICT

Name the regime and read the four instruments through it. This is oil-shock reflation — higher-for-longer, dollar-bid, risk-off. A global all-world equity book has held near its highs on AI and Asian strength, but carries the same duration and inflation risk; the global-bond sleeve is the disappointment, selling alongside stocks rather than steadying them. Gold is doing its job as the inflation hedge, firm though off January's peak; bitcoin trades as a high-beta risk asset here, not a haven. Singapore's record index is the local outlier. Explanation, not advice.³

TradingEconomics, CNBC, Bloomberg (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Don't trade this as a clean oil story. A large part of the yield surge is a fiscal, term-premium story — heavy government issuance in a higher-rate era — which means that even if Brent falls back to the eighties, long yields may not, and rate relief won't arrive as fast as an oil-only narrative implies. The bear case for bonds outlives the barrel.³

OIL SHOCK

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

DOLLAR BID

RISK-OFF

SOURCES 1 — Euronews, Bloomberg (ECB to 2.50%, 10 Sep); Yahoo Finance, Chase, CME FedWatch (Fed 15–16 Sep, hike odds ~mid-50s to ~two-thirds; BoJ leaning). 2 — Bloomberg, CNBC (10–11 Sep) — US 10Y ~4.96%, 30Y 19-yr high, JGB since 1996, Bund 2011 high; stocks and bonds falling together. 3 — TradingEconomics, Rigzone, CNBC (11 Sep) — Brent ~\$109.98, gold ~\$4,335, BTC ~\$77k, VWRA ~195 (6 Sep), STI ~5,807 record, DXY 99.11, USD/JPY 154.2; term-premium/fiscal read. Market explanation, not investment advice; forecasts flagged as forecasts.

DOWN THE RABBIT HOLE · THE INVITATION

Whisky, all the way down

Not the cocktail cabinet — the other obsession, where the bottle is the hero: a glass, a few drops of water, and the slow decoding of what a barrel and a decade did. Here is how the rabbit hole opens, and how far it goes.

It usually starts with one pour that rewrites the category. For some it is something that tastes, improbably, like a campfire — a peated Islay, a Laphroaig 10 or a Lagavulin 16. For others it is something like Christmas cake in a glass — a sherry-cask malt, a GlenDronach 12 or an Aberlour A'bunadh. Either way a single dram turns “harsh brown liquor” into a flavour map, and the rabbit hole opens.¹ This is whisky appreciation, and it is deliberately not mixology: no shaker, no mixer — a tulip glass, a drop of water, and the bottle as the whole event.¹

The world is bigger than the ritual suggests. The global whisky market was worth roughly seventy-seven billion dollars in 2025; Scotch alone about twenty-eight-and-a-half billion, and the single-malt niche around ten-and-a-half — with Asia-Pacific holding some forty-three per cent of single-malt demand, which puts Singapore near the category's centre of gravity.²

But the spine of the story is a boom that has turned. Scotch exports slipped to £5.3bn in 2025, down again by value and volume, after a 3.7% value fall in 2024; the United States — the biggest market — dropped around fifteen per cent by volume once a ten-per-cent US tariff landed in April 2025.² The collectable-bottle bubble that inflated through 2020–22 has burst: single-malt auction value fell about fifty-three per cent in the four months to the end of January 2025, the Rare Whisky 101 index was down roughly nine per cent on the year, and into 2025 the secondary market was reported off some forty per cent by value.³ Japanese whisky is hot but re-pricing

— Suntory raised Yamazaki and Hakushu prices around fifty per cent in 2024 and more again for 2026, even as a Yamazaki 55 has fetched roughly seven hundred and ninety-five thousand dollars at auction.³

-53%

SINGLE-MALT AUCTION VALUE, THE FOUR MONTHS TO END-JAN 2025 — THE COLLECTABLE BUBBLE DEFLATING

THE CHATTER · THE GATEWAY

Ask a room how they fell in and you get the same two answers — “the first peated one broke my brain” and “a sherry bomb tasted like dessert and I was gone.” The community's honest framing of the crash: it is good news for drinkers and bad news for speculators, because the liquid people actually open has never been better value against the hype.³

r/Scotch, Dramface (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC · READ THIS BEFORE THE SHELF

The single most dangerous phrase in the hobby is “whisky as an investment.” The boom that minted paper fortunes is the same boom that just wiped them; the numbers on the facing pages are a warning, not a brochure. Come for the drinking; treat any promise of a return as the tell it is.³

Five words to carry down: a *dram* is a pour; a *single malt* is malted-barley whisky from one distillery; *cask strength* is undiluted, around fifty-five to sixty-five per cent; NAS means no age statement; and the *angel's share* is the spirit that evaporates from the cask while it sleeps. The next two pages are the deep end.¹

SOURCES 1 — community lore, r/Scotch wiki, glass/tasting guides (gateway drams; the ritual; jargon). 2 — GMIInsights, Fortune Business Insights (market ~\$77.2bn 2025, Scotch ~\$28.6bn, single malt ~\$10.4bn, APAC ~43%); Scotch Whisky Association / thespiritsbusiness / drinks-intel (exports £5.4bn 2024 -3.7%, £5.3bn 2025; US -15% vol / 10% tariff Apr 2025). 3 — Decanter, thespiritsbusiness, Forbes/Mark Littler, Vinetur (secondary -53% Oct24–Jan25; RW101 -9%; -40% val 2025); sipjapan, thespiritsbusiness (Suntory +50%/>100% 2024, 2026 round); blockapps (Yamazaki 55 ~US\$795k). Figures as reported; verify before quoting.

THE DEEP END · THE MAP, THE GLASS, THE BOTTLES

Where they gather, what they pour it into, and what to actually buy

The community runs on a handful of forums and a one-man critic whose scores move prices; the gear is cheap; the money and the madness live in the bottles.

Start with the map. **r/Scotch** is the flagship — review-and-rating culture, fiercely anti-flipper — alongside **r/whisky** and **r/bourbon**. **Whiskybase** is the definitive database, the reference for provenance and market value; **Connosr** is the older, slower forum. The nearest thing to a Robert Parker is **Serge Valentin's WhiskyFun**, a near-daily one-man review site running twenty years whose hundred-point scores are influential enough to move prices on old and rare bottles.¹ The independent editorial voices — **Malt Review** and **Dramface** (which takes no freebies) — are prized for anti-hype honesty, and the on-ramp for most newcomers is YouTube: **Ralfy's** one-take reviews, **Aqvavitae's** weekly live sessions, the **Whisky Vault's** storytelling.¹

The kit is the cheapest part of any serious hobby. A **Glencairn** nosing glass — the tulip that concentrates the aroma — is about ten dollars, and is the one non-negotiable purchase; a stemmed **copita** is the step up for close nosing; the double-walled designer **Norlan** is the subject of a famous forum argument about form versus function.¹ Everything above a copita is taste, not need.

The money and the madness are in the bottles, up a ladder that suits a buy-once drinker. **Entry-of-quality** drams people genuinely respect: GlenDronach 12 (~US\$74), Lagavulin 16 (~US\$100), Talisker 10, Ardbeg 10, Springbank 10, and the perennial value pick Singleton 12 (~US\$45).² **The sweet spot** is the independent bottlers — Gordon & MacPhail, Signatory, Cadenhead's, Berry Bros. & Rudd, the playful That Boutique-y Whisky Co. — who bottle single casks the distilleries never release, often cask-strength and non-chill-filtered, with the

quality-to-price zone around fifty to ninety pounds.² **The grail** is where sense ends: Campbeltown's tiny **Springbank**, whose releases sell out in minutes and crash websites; the **Ardbeg Committee** bottling (the 2026 is a cask-strength Ten at 61.7%, £75); the Japanese unicorns; and the reopened ghost distilleries — **Port Ellen** came back on 19 March 2024 with a £45,000 "Gemini," **Brora** as part of Diageo's £185m revival.³ Macallan sits here as the community's standing argument about brand tax.³

~US\$10

A GLENCAIRN GLASS — THE ENTIRE REQUIRED KIT;
EVERYTHING ABOVE IT IS TASTE, NOT NEED

THE CHATTER · WHERE SINGAPORE BUYS

The local scene is tight and high-spend, orbiting a few names: **La Maison du Whisky** at Robertson Quay (a thousand-plus bottles and a deep by-the-dram menu), **The Auld Alliance** (Emmanuel Dron's bar, ~1,500 whiskies and its own single-cask releases, relocating to Capitol), **The Single Cask** at CHIJMES, and **1855**, home to a Macallan boutique. Online, the community buys from The Whisky Exchange, Master of Malt and the auction sites — friendlier to buyers since the crash.³ **whisky.sg, scotchwhisky.com, city guides (as reported)**

THE SCEPTIC

The ladder is a treadmill if you let it be. The distance in the glass between an eighty-dollar independent cask-strength and a four-figure allocation is far smaller than the price gap; most of what you pay above the sweet spot buys scarcity and a name, not flavour. The people happiest in this hobby drink the middle and visit the top through a bottle-share, not a mortgage.²

SOURCES 1 — Vinfolio/FINE+RARE (Serge Valentin influence), Connosr (Norlan/glass debate), firstphilwhisky (Ralfy/Aqvavitae/Whisky Vault), Dramface/Malt Review (independence) — community map & kit. 2 — Caskers, Whisky Marketplace, Forbes, Distiller (GlenDronach 12 ~\$74, Lagavulin 16 ~\$100, Singleton 12 ~\$45); tastescot (independent bottlers, £50–90 sweet spot). 3 — Scotsman/Dramface (Springbank/Campbeltown mania), whiskymonkeys/thedistilleryapp (Ardbeg Committee 2026, 61.7%, £75), whiskyadvocate/Decanter (Port Ellen 19 Mar 2024, Gemini £45,000; Brora/Diageo £185m); whisky.sg, scotchwhisky.com (LMDW, Auld Alliance, Single Cask, 1855). Prices convert/verify in SG.

THE DEEP END · THE EDGE, THE CON, AND THE WAY IN

A bloodbath at the top, a golden age at the bench

The cutting edge is two stories at once: an investment scam the community itself calls a reckoning, and a world-whisky boom that is quietly the best value in the glass.

The genuine news in whisky right now is not a bottle, it is a warning. Cask investment — buying a barrel to flip later — is unregulated by the Financial Conduct Authority, overseen only for tax, and it has become the hobby's biggest scam vector.¹ Britain's Insolvency Service wound up Cask Spirits Global after a probe found that of seventeen customers who paid £97,249, only four held valid ownership documents; the advertising regulator issued an enforcement notice in January 2024 over a misleading “582% ten-year return” claim, and a March 2025 BBC investigation amplified the calls for regulation.¹ One trade voice called the reckoning “a bloodbath.”¹

The happier edge is geographic. Taiwan's **Kavalan** was named 2026 Distiller of the Year at the World Whiskies Awards; India's **Amrut** and **Paul John** and England's **Cotswolds** and **Bimber** keep taking golds.² With Scotch re-pricing, world whisky is where quality-per-dollar now lives — the most honest “buy” story on the desk, and one the reader can act on without chasing an allocation.²

4 of 17

CASK SPIRITS GLOBAL CUSTOMERS WITH VALID OWNERSHIP PAPERS — THE SHAPE OF THE CASK-INVESTMENT CON

The culture, in brief. The factions are peat-heads (Islay smoke) versus sherry-bombs versus bourbon-cask purists who want to taste the distillery, not the wood — and, increasingly, Scotch snobbery versus a world-whisky openness that is winning credibility.² The vocabulary is its own gate — NCF (non-chill-filtered), *dusty* (an old bottle off a back shelf), *unicorn* and *whale* (the near-unobtainable), *flipper* (the reseller the community reviles). The calendar peaks at **Fèis Ìle**, the Islay festival in late May, the hobby's

Mecca; the community's answer to unaffordable grails is the **bottle-share**, splitting one expensive bottle into sample vials.²

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Lurk before you spend — the r/Scotch value lists and a few Ralfy reviews cost nothing. Buy the ten-dollar Glencairn, not a designer glass. Then a starter flight of one from each pole to find your camp: a peated Islay, a sherried Highland (GlenDronach 12), and a balanced bourbon-cask malt — roughly US\$180–250 all in, converted and marked up in Singapore.³ Do one by-the-dram session at LMDW or the Auld Alliance before buying any bottle over about S\$150. Do not buy a cask “investment,” a hyped allocation, or a designer glass yet.³

r/Scotch wiki, LMDW dram menu (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The community's own confession, when pressed: cask investment is a scam frontier; the 2020–22 “collectors” are underwater; No-Age-Statement releases sell story where years used to be; and flippers hollow out the point — sealed bottles nobody drinks. Buy on taste, not on label romance, and the Macallan logo tax stays on the shelf.¹

NEXT DESCENTS · VOTE TOMORROW'S RABBIT HOLE

Home espresso — the buy-once machine-and-grinder chase, where a mid-40s perfectionist tries to beat the café at his own counter.

Fountain pens — analogue daily-carry obsession, from a fifty-dollar gateway nib to grail Japanese urushi lacquer.

Freshwater aquascaping — living underwater gardens as slow, high-craft interior design: plants, hardscape, patience and expensive light.

SOURCES 1 — whiskyinvestments (FCA gap), gov.uk Insolvency Service (Cask Spirits Global; £97,249 / 17 / 4 valid), Brodies (ASA Jan-2024 enforcement, 582% claim), thedrinksbusiness/thespiritsbusiness (“bloodbath”; BBC Mar-2025). 2 — PRNewswire (Kavalan 2026 Distiller of the Year), thespiritsbusiness/thewhiskeywash (Amrut/Paul John/Cotswolds/Bimber); scotchwhisky.com (factions/Fèis Ìle/glossary). 3 — r/Scotch wiki, Forbes/Distiller (starter flight ~US\$180–250), whisky.sg (LMDW/Auld Alliance dram menus). Prices convert/verify in SG; community sentiment attributed, not invented.

THE LONG GAME · THE DOSE THAT'S ENOUGH

Two hours of lifting a week, and the longevity curve flattens

A 2026 analysis of long-term resistance training finds the mortality benefit plateauing around a hundred and twenty minutes a week — the rare fitness headline that gives you permission to stop.

The useful news in strength science this year is a ceiling, not a floor. A 2026 study in the *British Journal of Sports Medicine* on long-term resistance training and mortality found that moderate weekly strength work was associated with lower all-cause mortality — with the risk reduction flattening around a hundred and twenty minutes a week, and resistance-plus-aerobic beating aerobic alone.¹ For a mid-forties reader that reframes the whole guilt economy of the gym: you do not need to live there. Ninety to a hundred and twenty minutes of strength, layered on your cardio, is where the curve bends.¹

The supporting lever is aerobic fitness itself. Large cohort work has each one-MET gain in capacity associated with roughly twelve to fifteen per cent lower mortality — which is why the strongest package pairs a couple of hundred minutes of easy Zone-2 cardio with two or three strength sessions, rather than chasing one at the expense of the other.¹ And if you want one cheap, well-studied addition, a 2026 double-blind crossover trial found short-term creatine monohydrate enhanced strength, cut fatigue and sped recovery in trained adults — building on the 2024 meta-analysis for strength gains.²

~120 min

WEEKLY STRENGTH WORK WHERE THE MORTALITY BENEFIT
PLATEAUS — MORE ISN'T SHOWN TO ADD

THE CHATTER

The longevity-podcast crowd — the Attia-and-Huberman-adjacent set — will seize on the hundred-and-twenty-minute figure as vindication that “strength is the pillar people skip,” folding it into the “centenarian decathlon” of trainable metrics: grip, leg strength, VO2 max. Useful framing; just remember it is discourse riffing on an association, not a clinical prescription.²

longevity podcasts, r/fitness (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Read the design before the takeaway. The BJSM and the MET-mortality findings are observational associations, not causal proof — healthier people train more, which flatters the numbers. The plateau at two hours is an association, not a shown “optimal dose”; more has not been shown to harm, and the true best amount is soft. Resist the maximalist read. General information, not medical advice — anyone with a cardiac or joint history should clear a load ramp with a doctor first.²

ALSO WORTH TRYING

Mind the GLP-1 activity drop. People on the new weight-loss drugs tend to move and train less, risking lean-mass loss — which makes strength work matter more on the medication, not less. A note for the reader tracking the wellness cycle, not a prescription.

SOURCES 1 — British Journal of Sports Medicine (2026) resistance-training & all-cause mortality (benefit plateau ~120 min/wk; RT+aerobic > aerobic alone), via secondary write-up — confirm the BJSM DOI before quoting; JAMA (2018, 120k+ patients) 1-MET / ~12–15% mortality. 2 — PMC12833896 (2026 creatine crossover trial), PMC creatine+RT meta (2024); longevity-discourse framing (as reported). General information, not medical advice.

DEPARTURES · EX-SINGAPORE, WHAT CHANGED

The autumn network wave, and a lounge mid-glow-up

The summer capacity tweaks are unwinding into a fourth-quarter long-haul wave; Scoot points at Okinawa by year-end; and the SilverKris lounge you use is halfway through a rebuild while the RTS Link runs its final tests.

The delta for a Singapore flyer this fortnight is mostly forward-looking. Singapore Airlines' northern-summer tweaks — a fifth weekly Cairns, the de-linked Milan-Barcelona tag — are unwinding, and the real news is the fourth-quarter long-haul wave landing October to December: a new Western Sydney service, restored Madrid, and more Dubai and Riyadh.¹ Bangkok is now seven-times daily; Yangon up to ten weekly.¹

The one to file for a year-end leisure trip: Scoot begins a direct Singapore–Okinawa (Naha) service in November 2026, turning a beach-and-onsen island into a single hop — and a candidate for a future Grand Tour (p21).¹

On the ground, two milestones. SIA's S\$45m Terminal 2 SilverKris rebuild opened its Business Class in phases through 2026, with a second phase due around September adding half again as much seating — so the lounge is mid-upgrade now.² And the Johor Bahru–Singapore RTS Link, past ninety per cent built, is entering a sustained fault-free test run around September, with passenger service still targeted for January 2027; T5's underground tunnels to T2 are complete.²

Nov 2026

SCOOT'S DIRECT SINGAPORE–OKINAWA LAUNCH — A ONE-HOP BEACH-AND-ONSEN ISLAND FOR THE YEAR-END

THE CHATTER · POINTS

The miles crowd is grumbling, with cause. After the November 2025 KrisFlyer devaluation, the programme trimmed its dynamic "Access" award rates again in March 2026 — up to about eleven per cent less value in economy and premium. The standing counsel on the boards: chase Saver space, not Access, and book award seats the day they open.²

MileLion, FlyerTalk (as reported)

The reader's takeaway for the year-end diary: the summer's network noise is settling into a genuinely useful autumn map — a new Australian city, restored European capitals, an Okinawa hop, and a lounge worth the wait once its second phase opens. Book the long-haul on the schedule, not the rumour, and check the SilverKris status before you plan a long connection through Terminal 2.²

NEW ROUTE

LOUNGE

RTS LINK

POINTS

STILL ON THE RADAR

Jetstar Asia, still gone. The intra-Asia carrier ceased in July 2025; sixteen routes withdrew and the jets went to Australia and New Zealand — relevant only as the reason some 2024-era routings no longer exist.¹

Bangkok, now hourly-ish. SIA's seven-daily Bangkok and ten-weekly Yangon are the quiet workhorses of the ex-Singapore map — frequency, not fanfare, and the reason a weekend in either is easy to slot.¹

The T5 tunnels are done. The underground link from the future Terminal 5 to Terminal 2 is complete — a milestone for the airport's next decade, filed for the long view, not this year's trip.²

SOURCES 1 — Singapore Airlines newsroom, MainlyMiles, Yahoo Finance (SIA 2026 schedule: Cairns 5x, Milan–Barcelona de-link, Q4 Western Sydney/Madrid/Dubai/Riyadh; Bangkok 7x, Yangon 10x); Scoot (SIN–Okinawa Nov 2026); Aviation Week (Jetstar Asia exit Jul 2025). 2 — MainlyMiles (T2 SilverKris Business phases, Phase 2 ~Sep 2026), jbskyone (RTS Link ~90%+, fault-free test ~Sep 2026, service Jan 2027); MileLion (KrisFlyer Nov-2025 deval + Mar-2026 Access cut). Verify schedules/award rates before booking.

DEPARTURES · THE FINE PRINT THAT COSTS MONEY

Japan changes the shopping rules; Europe delays the app

Two Japan tax changes matter to the reader before year-end, Europe's new biometric border is live but its travel-permit slips to 2027, and the typhoon calendar deserves a look but not a scare.

The Japan changes are the ones to diarise. The international tourist departure tax — the “sayonara tax” — tripled from a thousand yen to three thousand on 1 July 2026, small and usually bundled into the fare, but now in force.¹ The bigger one lands 1 November: Japan abolishes the instant point-of-sale tax exemption for tourists, so you pay the full tax-inclusive price and claim a refund at departure instead, with no transition period.¹ For the reader who works the Ginza camera and watch counters, the Leica-and-Grand-Seiko routine changes six weeks from this edition — pay now, refund at the airport, and leave within ninety days.¹

Europe is the mirror image — a border tightening, a permit slipping. The biometric Entry/Exit System is now operational and adding fingerprinting queues at summer peaks; but ETIAS, the travel authorisation, has quietly dropped its 2026 date and is now widely expected in 2027.² Net for a 2026 or early-2027 Europe leg: no ETIAS fee or permit needed yet — just budget time for the biometric queue. Bali's tourist levy, meanwhile, holds steady at about ten US dollars; a mooted rise is unconfirmed.²

1 Nov

JAPAN ENDS INSTANT TAX-FREE SHOPPING — FULL PRICE AT THE TILL, REFUND AT THE AIRPORT

THE SCEPTIC · THE TYPHOON NOTE

Forecasters call for a busier-than-average 2026 Pacific season, and September is peak for Japan-approaching tracks — worth building slack into a mid-autumn itinerary. But we could not verify a live named system threatening Honshu the week of this edition, so we print the caution, not a track. Watch the JMA, not a headline.²

Two more the reader should file. KrisFlyer trimmed its dynamic “Access” award rates again in March, on top of the November 2025 devaluation — the redemption drift is now a pattern, and Saver space is where the value survives (p19).² And on the ground in Japan, the tax-free change pairs with the weak-but-firming yen to reshape the shopping trip: the two together mean the “give-it-away” Japan of 2024 is over, and the arithmetic now rewards planning — buy the big-ticket camera or watch on one trip, claim the refund on the way out, and do it before the November switch.¹

FOR THE LEDGER · THE 2026 OPENINGS

Japan's landmark year. The 1 Hotel Tokyo (Akasaka), Rosewood Miyakojima in Okinawa, and Hoshinoya's conversion of the former Nara prison into forty-eight suites are the year's marquee openings — long-lead, filed for the trip you plan, not the one you book today.²

Okinawa gets closer. Scoot's November direct to Naha (p19) lands the same year Rosewood opens on Miyakojima — a new luxury-beach-Japan pairing worth a future Grand Tour, and a candidate now on the pipeline.²

The gear cross-reference. The travel-audio and carry conversation lives on The Kit (p9); the yen read that makes the shopping maths sits on The Macro Desk (p14). We hand off rather than duplicate.

SOURCES 1 — Japan Times (departure tax ¥1,000 → ¥3,000, 1 Jul 2026); Japan Guide (tax-free reform, refund-at-departure from 1 Nov 2026, 90-day rule). 2 — Fragomen (EU EES live, ETIAS slips to 2027); The Bali Sun (levy ~US\$10, steady); Tokyo Weekender (2026 typhoon-season forecast, no verified live Honshu system this week); Travel Industry Today (1 Hotel Tokyo, Rosewood Miyakojima, Hoshinoya Nara). Verify entry rules and openings before travel.

THE GRAND TOUR · HAKONE & THE FUJI FIVE LAKES

The mountain that hides from anyone who came for the postcard

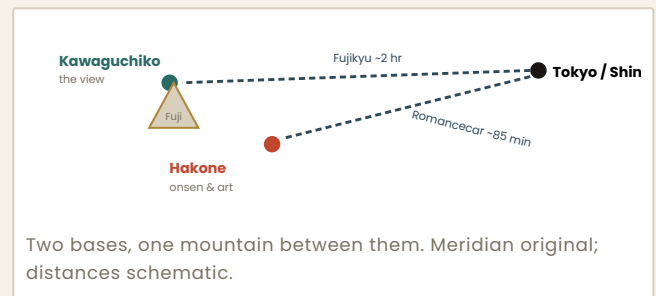
Two Fuji experiences sit forty kilometres apart and get confused for one trip. Hakone is onsen and world-class art, with Fuji an occasional bonus; Kawaguchiko is the mountain itself. Come in September and you get the baths, not the view.

Lead with the correction, because it is the trip's most common disappointment: Hakone is not where you go for the picture of Fuji. Hakone is an onsen-and-art resort in the hills, where the mountain shows itself on a clear, cold day and hides the rest of the time; Kawaguchiko, one of the Fuji Five Lakes, is where the mountain stands over the water and gives you the reflection.¹ Decide which you came for before you book, or you will base in the wrong place.¹

When to go, honestly. This edition's mid-September window is the weakest for the view — late-summer haze and the peak of the Japan-approaching typhoon season, which can suspend the ropeway, the lake boats and a rail line for a day (p20). Fine for baths and museums, poor odds for a crisp Fuji.¹ The windows to actually chase are the autumn foliage around mid-November — Hakone's connoisseur season, and its most crowded — and the cold, dry clarity of December to February, the best time for the Kawaguchiko photograph. Plan the flights for a November or winter booking, not a September dash.¹

Getting there. Singapore to Tokyo is about seven hours nonstop; Haneda sits closer to the start. From Shinjuku, the Odakyu Romancecar reaches Hakone-Yumoto in roughly eighty-five minutes, and the Hakone Free Pass — about ¥7,100 for two days — covers the mountain railway, cablecar, ropeway, lake boats and buses, with the Romancecar seat a small surcharge on top.² Kawaguchiko is a separate base, reached via the Fujikyu line in about two hours; treat

the two as different trips, not a same-day hop.² The yen sits near a hundred and fifty-four to the dollar — stronger than a year ago but still historically weak, so Japan is “still good value,” not “cheaper than ever” (p14).²



¥7,100

HAKONE FREE PASS (2-DAY) — IT PAYS FOR ITSELF ON TWO OR THREE LEGS OF THE LOOP

Where to base. In Hakone, Gora is the pick for a first-timer — mid-mountain, walking distance to the museums, and the top ryokan tier; Sengokuhara is quieter, Lake Ashi scenic-but-spread-out, Yumoto a transit town. The ryokan is the destination here: the kaiseki half-board and a private open-air bath are the experience, so a genuine ryokan beats a business hotel decisively.² The buy-once names — per night, two guests, usually dinner and breakfast in: Gora Kadan from around ¥120,000, the cliff-side Hakone Ginyu with a private bath in every room, and Hoshino Resorts' KAI Hakone as the accessible-luxury entry.² For the mountain view, Kozantei Ubuya at Kawaguchiko faces Fuji from every window, from about ¥90,000.²

SOURCES 1 — JapanTravel, Magical Trip, trip-report aggregations (Hakone vs Kawaguchiko; September typhoon/haze shoulder; koyo ~mid-Nov; winter Fuji clarity). 2 — Odakyu Global (Romancecar ~85 min; Hakone Free Pass ~¥7,100/2-day + Romancecar surcharge), Tokyo Cheapo (Fujikyu ~2 hr); TradingEconomics (USD/JPY ~154, 11 Sep); GLTJP/ryokan guides (Gora Kadan from ~¥120,000, Hakone Ginyu, KAI Hakone; Kozantei Ubuya from ~¥90,000). Rates swing by season/room; verify at booking.

THE GRAND TOUR · WHAT ACTUALLY EARNS THE TRIP

The art is world-class, the loop is a queue, and the eggs are black

Overnight for the museums and the onsen dinner, time the torii shot for dawn, feed the twelve-year-old to Fuji-Q — and read what the forums say before you build the day.

The strongest reason to sleep in Hakone rather than day-trip is the art. The Hakone Open-Air Museum, with its dedicated Picasso pavilion, and the Pola Museum's Impressionists in a glass-and-forest building are genuinely world-class, not filler.¹ The famous circuit — the Tozan railway switchbacks, the Sounzan cablecar, the Owakudani ropeway over the sulphur vents, the Lake Ashi “pirate ship,” and the Hakone Shrine torii standing in the water — is a great sequence of frames, but warn the reader that the torii shot now carries a queue of about an hour, and the ropeway can be wind- or gas-suspended (buses substitute).¹ At Owakudani's volcanic Alert Level 1 the valley is open; confirm the live level the morning of, because it is the trip's single biggest point of failure. The black eggs boiled in the vents — kurotamago — are the ritual snack.¹

For the postcard, go to Kawaguchiko for the lakeshore reflection and to the Chureito Pagoda at Arakurayama in nearby Fujiyoshida — but arrive before nine to beat the tour buses; the town cancelled its 2026 cherry festival outright, citing overtourism on residents, which is the hard fact behind “it's gotten crowded.”¹ Two corrections for the itinerary: the Little Prince Museum has been permanently closed since 2023 — do not list it — while the Venetian Glass Museum remains the better “pretty museum” stop. For a twelve-year-old, Fuji-Q Highland's record-holding coasters sit five minutes from Kawaguchiko station — the day the parents do the pagoda-and-lake circuit.¹

before 9am

ARRIVE AT THE CHUREITO PAGODA TO BEAT THE BUSES —
THE 2026 CHERRY FESTIVAL WAS CANCELLED FOR
OVERTOURISM

Food and the practicalities. The headline meal is the ryokan kaiseki that the room rate pays for; beyond it, Gora is known for soba and soft tofu, and Yamanashi's regional signatures — hoto, a flat-noodle-and-pumpkin miso hotpot, and famously chewy Fujiyoshida udon — are worth the detour.² On family logistics: ryokan welcome children, and a room with a private open-air bath sidesteps both the mixed-bathing question with a pre-teen and the tattoo rule that still bars visible ink from many public onsen. On money, the shape is simple — spend on the ryokan half-board, which dominates the budget, and save on transport, where the Free Pass pays for itself.²

WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY

The consensus across the trip-report threads is consistent: Hakone is “too large to see in one day,” and those who overnight for the museums and a proper onsen dinner call it “really worth it,” while day-trippers get funnelled onto the round course and rush it. The loudest dissent is the Fuji let-down — visitors expecting the mountain *from Hakone* are “frequently disappointed,” and the repeated steer is to base at Kawaguchiko if the view is the goal. Winter is quietly recommended for the clearest Fuji and thinner crowds. Attributed as forum sentiment; the hard facts above are verified separately.²

Fodor's Asia forum; published trip reports (as reported)

HAND-OFF

The dated agenda is next door. Bookable events at and near the destination live on The Diary (p23) — the Travel Desk sets the place, the Diary carries the dates.

SOURCES 1 — JapanTravel, jeepe.jp, Magical Trip, Wikipedia (Hakone Open-Air/Picasso & Pola museums; the loop & torii queue; Owakudani Alert Level 1 & kurotamago; Chureito Pagoda/Arakurayama, arrive <9am, 2026 Fujiyoshida cherry festival cancelled; Little Prince Museum closed since 2023; Venetian Glass Museum open; Fuji-Q). 2 — regional food guides (kaiseki, Gora soba/tofu, hoto, Fujiyoshida udon); onsen etiquette/tattoo notes; Free Pass value; Fodor's Asia forum & trip reports (day-trip vs overnight; Fuji cloud-cover dissent; winter steer). Forum sentiment attributed; hard facts verified.

WHAT'S WORTH BOOKING · THE DATED AGENDA

What to book this week — and to plan the flights for

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

9–11
OCT

★ Singapore Grand Prix

MARINA BAY · FIRST-EVER F1 SPRINT · THE KILLERS (10 OCT), LANA DEL REY (11 OCT), JJ LIN, JANET JACKSON, ZARA LARSSON

2–3
OCT

★ The Weeknd

NATIONAL STADIUM · AFTER HOURS TIL DAWN · SUPPORT CREEPY NUTS · FIRST SG SHOWS SINCE 2018

14
SEP

Bruno Mars — general sale

THE ROMANTIC TOUR · NAT. STADIUM · SHOWS 13/14/17/18 APR 2027 · 10AM TODAY

30
SEP

★ Snow City — final day

CLOSES FOR GOOD AFTER 26 YEARS · A LAST-CHANCE SNOW OUTING FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD

28–29
NOV

BABYMONSTER — [CHOOM]

SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · S\$168–358 · FAMILY-FRIENDLY

17–22
DEC

BTS — ARIRANG (sold out)

NATIONAL STADIUM · 4 NIGHTS · LONGEST ASIAN RUN OUTSIDE KOREA/JAPAN · RESALE ONLY

20
FEB

YOASOBI

NATIONAL STADIUM (2027) · FIRST JAPANESE ACT TO HEADLINE IT · ONLY SEA STOP

19
Sep–22
Nov

Deepavali light-up

LITTLE INDIA · DEEPAVALI 8 NOV · FREE EVENING WALK

PLANNING NOTES

The 14th is the trigger. Bruno Mars' general sale opens 10am today for four April-2027 nights — register before it opens; four-night National Stadium runs clear fast.¹

The 19th, then the 28th. Kyushu sumo tickets open 19 September (weekends and the final three days go within hours), and the Orsay advance window opens 28 September — both worth an alarm.²

Then the 30th. Snow City shuts for good on the 30th — a genuine last chance for the family, and the Deepavali walk opens the same fortnight.¹

Pair the flights. Fukuoka sumo (8–22 Nov) chains into Tokyo's illuminations and the Orsay show — Kyushu first, then the capital for the lights and the leaves.²

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

8–22
NOV

★ Kyushu Basho (Grand Sumo)

FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · TICKETS ON-SALE 19 SEP (TICKET OOSUMO) · WEEKENDS SELL IN HOURS

28
SEP

★ Musée d'Orsay masterworks

TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM · ADVANCE TIX FROM 28 SEP · ~110 WORKS, VAN GOGH/MILLET · RUN DATES VERIFY

29
NOV

ENHYPEN — BLOOD SAGA

TOKYO DOME · K-POP MARQUEE FOR A TOKYO TRIP

Nov–Jan

Tokyo winter illuminations

MEGA ILLUMI AT OI RACECOURSE, MARUNOUCHI, YOMIURILAND · SWITCH-ON EARLY–MID NOV

21–22
NOV

Hachioji Ginkgo Festival

TOKYO · GOLDEN TREES ALONG A 4KM AVENUE · FAMILY-FRIENDLY

THE CHATTER

The resale boards' standing counsel for the National Stadium headliners: on-sales announce months ahead and clear in a single window, so the discipline is calendar-first — register interest, set the alarm, decide the seats before the queue, not during it.¹

resale forums, Live Nation SG (as reported)

THE STILL-ON CHECK

Every row here was re-checked against a promoter, venue or official ticketing page, not an aggregator. Post Malone stays off the calendar — reported cancelled, no new date. The Orsay run dates are held to “verify” because the museum's own page could not be reached at press time. A listing is a fact only while it is still on.

SOURCES 1 — Formula1.com/Time Out SG, Live Nation SG, STB, RedHot, Mothership (Sep 2026) — F1 SG 9–11 Oct (first Sprint; Killers 10 Oct/Lana Del Rey 11 Oct); The Weeknd 2–3 Oct; Bruno Mars general sale 14 Sep (Apr 2027); BABYMONSTER 28–29 Nov; BTS 17–22 Dec (sold out); YOASOBI 20 Feb 2027; Snow City final day 30 Sep; Deepavali light-up 19 Sep–22 Nov. 2 — japaneventsguide/Ticket Oosumo, JapanTravel, Tokyo Dome, JapanTravel illuminations (Kyushu Basho 8–22 Nov, on-sale 19 Sep; Orsay @ Tokyo Met, advance from 28 Sep, run dates unverified; ENHYPEN 29 Nov Tokyo Dome; Tokyo illuminations Nov–Jan; Hachioji Ginkgo 21–22 Nov). Verify on primary ticketing before booking.

THE TABLE · SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

Two intimate counters, and a New York name lands

What has just opened, and whether it earns the trip — a ten-seat yakitori omakase, an East-side kappo counter built on aged wagyu, a cult NYC bakery's first Southeast Asian outpost, and a Hong Kong teppan steakhouse going premium.

The month's most Diary-worthy opening is the smallest. **Toriei**, on the fourth floor of Cuppage Plaza off Orchard, is a ten-seat, counter-only yakitori omakase from Chef Roy Koh of Skewers — his premium step up from the casual original, everything grilled over charcoal in front of you.¹ Early coverage is warm and positions it as a serious, intimate upgrade, but it is too new for a broad verdict; treat it as promising, not proven, and book, because ten seats vanish.¹

Out east, **Kappo Suguru** at 192 Joo Chiat is the other counter worth the trip — from the Suguru Home Dining team, running kappo omakase on Sundays to Tuesdays and a sushiya the rest of the week.¹ Reviewers single out a tallow-aged A5 wagyu; the omakase runs from about S\$180++ and an eleven-course seasonal from S\$250++. It is positively received but early, and part of a genuine Joo Chiat-Katong dining surge — book the counter ahead.¹

The import everyone will ask about is **The City Bakery**, the cult New York bakery-café, which opened its first Southeast Asian outpost at Mandarin Gallery on 13 August — the pretzel croissant and thick hot chocolate that made its name in tow.² The honest counsel on a heritage-name arrival is caution: the opening curiosity is real, but imports like this often draw early queues that settle, and a first-month room deserves a second visit before a verdict.²

For a counter with a view of the flame, **Bari Bari** — the Hong Kong teppan-steak concept — has opened a more premium flagship at Capitol Kempinski in the Civic District after debuting at Tampines 1.² The teppan-steak-at-your-counter format is proven locally and travels well; the flagship is too new to call, but it is the more Diary-worthy of its two rooms.²

Read as a set, the month rewards the intimate over the imported. The two Japanese counters — Toriei and Kappo Suguru — are the genuinely new experiences worth planning around; The City Bakery and Bari Bari are the ones to let settle before you queue. For a family meal with a twelve-year-old, the bakery travels best; the ten-seat counters are outings for the grown-ups.¹

THE BUZZ · THE VERDICT

The pattern this month is intimate counters and a marquee import over big splashy concepts. The fresh-concept excitement sits with the two Japanese omakase rooms, positively but thinly reviewed so far; where a place has only just landed — The City Bakery, the Bari Bari flagship — the honest line is “too new to call,” and anticipation is not the same as quality.¹

The Ranting Panda, HungryGoWhere, Eatbook, middleclass.sg (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

A heritage name is not a review. The City Bakery arrives on a New York reputation and Bari Bari on a Hong Kong one, but a first-week Singapore outlet earns its stars here, not abroad — and a ten-seat omakase with two weeks of coverage is a promise, not a consensus. Give the new rooms a month and a second visit before the verdict; the queue is measuring novelty, not the kitchen.²

ALSO JUST LANDED

Torikizoku, VivoCity. The iconic Japanese yakitori chain opened what it calls its largest outlet worldwide — 174 seats — the cheerful, cheap end of the counter trend, and the family-friendly counterpoint to Toriei's ten-seat omakase.²

Cloudmills, Orchard. A Japan-inspired bakery with a menu by a MasterChef Singapore runner-up — the pastry arrival to watch once the opening queue settles.²

THE TABLE

TORIEI

KAPPO SUGURU

SOURCES 1 — The Ranting Panda (Toriei @ Cuppage, 10-seat yakitori omakase, Chef Roy Koh/Skewers; Kappo Suguru @ Joo Chiat, omakase from S\$180++, 11-course from S\$250++, aged A5 wagyu), OpenRice (Aug–Sep 2026). 2 — middleclass.sg (The City Bakery @ Mandarin Gallery, first SEA outpost, opened 13 Aug), HungryGoWhere new-openings (Bari Bari HK teppan-steak flagship @ Capitol Kempinski; Torikizoku @ VivoCity, 174 seats; Cloudmills @ Orchard). Buzz summarised from cited food media/socials in our words; verify hours before visiting.

THE UNDERCURRENT · TAIWAN

The island that built itself a paycheck

Eighteen million times over, Taiwanese have bought into dividend funds that pay a little every month — the “存股族,” the stock-saving tribe, manufacturing a synthetic salary the wage and the pension no longer provide. In 2026, for the first time, they began quietly walking away from the funds that defined the craze.

Count the holdings and it sounds like an entire nation at the trough. By July 2026 the number of beneficiary accounts across Taiwan-listed-stock ETFs had broken eighteen million — spread over ninety-three funds, adding some two hundred and thirty thousand in a single week, a fourth straight record.¹ Against a population of about twenty-three million, the figure invites the headline that everyone in Taiwan now owns an ETF. Resist it: the count tallies holdings *per fund*, so one person in five funds is counted five times; the more person-like number, record brokerage accounts nearer fourteen-and-a-half million, is still extraordinary, but it is not the island entire.¹

What is not overstated is the tilt. Taiwan's ETF assets have grown some twenty-two-fold in five years to around three-point-nine trillion New Taiwan dollars — the third-largest pool in Asia — and, uniquely in the world, more than sixty per cent of it sits in *high-dividend* funds, roughly double what is held in the market-cap trackers a Western saver would default to.¹ The tribe has a name, 存股族, the “stock-saving tribe,” and a signature product: the 月月配, the “monthly-monthly” fund that pays a distribution every single month.²

They did not buy a return. They bought the feeling of a paycheck.

The emblem is a fund with a number for a name. When 00940 launched in March 2024, it and one rival pulled in some two hundred and twenty billion New Taiwan dollars in a single month; demand crashed brokerage systems, and savers cashed out time deposits and even took loans to get in.² Its pitch was never capital growth. It was the monthly cheque — a distribution raised in August 2026 to about five-point-three per cent annualised, comfortably above the market's cash yield.² This is the thing to understand about the whole phenomenon: the 月月配 is not really an investment product. It is an income-subscription product, bought and felt as a wage top-up and a do-it-yourself pension.

UNDER THE RADAR

The check for whether this desk is early: no NYT, BBC, Reuters, FT, CNN or Guardian feature exists on the culture of Taiwan's dividend-ETF tribe or its 2026 reversal. The only Western-wire touch is a Bloomberg markets item on fund flows into the big market-cap tracker — a plumbing story, not this one. The trend and its unravelling are, so far, un-covered in the West.¹

CommonWealth, Taipei Times, bnext, Newtalk (as reported)

To see why a country would do this — engineer a salary out of the stock market — you have to look at what the salary itself stopped doing. That is the next page.²

SOURCES 1 — Newtalk (21 Jul 2026, ETF beneficiaries >18m across 93 funds, +-230k/wk), Taipei Times (12 Aug 2026, ~18.2m vs ~23m population; brokerage accounts ~14.6m, single-sourced/held), CommonWealth Magazine (Vol. 795, 3 Apr 2024, ETF assets ~22.7× in 5 yrs to ~NT\$3.9tn, >60% in high-dividend — ~2yr-old figures). Bloomberg (27 Mar 2026, 0050 flows — markets story, not the culture). 2 — CommonWealth (00940 launch Mar 2024, ~NT\$220bn/month, systems crash, deposits/loans); BigGo Finance (00940 Aug-2026 distribution ~NT\$0.055, ~5.3% annualised). Beneficiary counts are per-fund holdings, not unique investors.

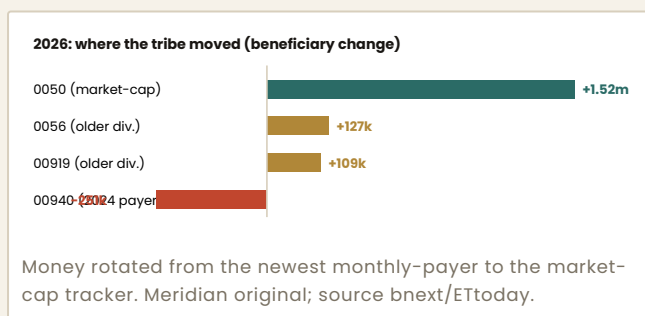
THE UNDERCURRENT · THE FIRST CRACK

The tribe deserts the funds that made it — while they're still up

In 2026, even in a roaring market, the newest monthly-payers began bleeding holders. The reason is a quiet realisation: the cheque was partly their own money handed back.

Here is the crack. In 2026 the flagship 00940 lost some two hundred and fifty thousand beneficiaries — a fall of roughly forty-four per cent, the worst of the twenty-three big high-dividend funds, and nine of the ten heaviest bleeders were high-dividend too.¹ The money did not leave the market; it *rotated*. The big market-cap tracker 0050 gained about one-and-a-half million beneficiaries over the year, the older dividend funds 0056 and 00919 kept adding holders, and active ETFs surged.¹ The tell is which funds bled: the newest, boom-era monthly-payers born in 2023 and 2024, while the older names held.¹

The trigger was performance meeting arithmetic. A roaring index — up around fifty-six per cent for the year with dividends — left the high-dividend funds trailing by six to eleven points, and in a bull run that gap is impossible to ignore.¹ Behind it sat a harder word the retail crowd began using: 吃老本, “eating into your own nest egg” — the recognition that part of a fat monthly “dividend” is simply your own capital handed back, dressed as income.²



A country that stopped trusting the wage decided to manufacture one.

Step back and the argument is bigger than a fund flow. Taiwan has *financialised the paycheck*. In a super-aged society with two decades of near-stagnant real wages and a public pension almost nobody trusts, households used the stock market to build the monthly income their salaries and their state no longer reliably deliver.² The 月月配 was the instrument, and its appeal, as one business title put it, was psychological before it was financial: the wish to “save steadily,” to “see cash flow,” and not to have to research a single stock.² People bought the feeling of a wage. 2026 is the year some of them noticed the difference between that feeling and a return.²

The split now running through the tribe is generational, and it is the tell. The younger cohort — the twenty-somethings just starting to invest — tilts toward market-cap and growth, the “build the capital first, seek the income later” logic; the older savers, past fifty, cling to the monthly cheque and its feeling of security.² That is not two strategies so much as two relationships with the wage: one still expects a career to build wealth, the other has stopped, and is buying the pension it no longer trusts anyone else to provide.² When a country’s young and old disagree about whether to chase income or growth, they are really disagreeing about whether the future will pay.

-44%

THE FLAGSHIP MONTHLY-PAYER’S BENEFICIARY FALL IN 2026 — THE TRIBE DESERTING THE FUND THAT DEFINED IT

SOURCES 1 — bnext/BusinessNext (2026 ETF holder ranking: 00940 --250,521 / --44%; 9 of 10 biggest losers high-dividend; 0050 +-1.52m, 0056 +126,718, 00919 +108,626; active 00981A surging; market +-56.3% YTD vs 0056 -50.3%, 00919 -45.4%), ETtoday. 2 — bnext (the “穩穩存 / 現金流 / no-research” framing), CTITV/finance commentary (吃老本 discourse). Generational-split figures held pending primary (AmCham, Sep 2026). Sentiment attributed as reported.

THE UNDERCURRENT • THE PRECEDENT, AND THE DOUBT

We have seen this instinct before — it wore a housewife's name

Japan's "Mrs. Watanabe" manufactured income out of the currency market a generation ago, for the same reasons. What she teaches is both why Taiwan's tribe formed and how fragile a wage built from financial structure can be.

The precedent is Japanese, and it is instructive. Through the Lost Decade — stagnant wages, deposit rates at the floor — millions of Japanese retail investors, archetypally the housewife the market nicknamed "Mrs. Watanabe," manufactured the income their savings accounts no longer paid through leveraged foreign-exchange carry trades: borrow yen at nearly nothing, buy high-yielding Australian and New Zealand dollars, pocket the difference.¹ By 2007 Japanese retail was trading some nine billion US dollars of currency a day — roughly a fifth of Tokyo's session — before the 2008 crisis unwound it and regulators capped retail leverage.¹

The engine is identical: a rich, aging, low-yield, wage-stagnant society; the same instinct to engineer a synthetic income to replace what wages and interest no longer give; and the same fragility, because income built from financial structure rather than earned cash flow can reprice overnight. Taiwan's 存股族 are Mrs. Watanabe's heirs, swapping the carry trade for the dividend fund.¹

When a society stops believing the wage will provide, financial products become emotional infrastructure.

That is the meaning worth carrying out of Taiwan, and it is bigger than one island's fund flows. When people stop believing that work and the state will provide an income, they build one out of whatever instrument is to hand — a carry trade, a monthly-dividend ETF — and they attach to it the trust they once placed in an employer and a pension. Taiwan,

the leading edge of East Asia's super-aged, low-fertility, low-yield future, is showing Korea, China and the rest what a household does when the wage stops working: it manufactures one, and it grows fond of the machine.²

THE SCEPTIC • WHAT WOULD PROVE US WRONG

Read the exodus the other way and it is maturation, not disillusionment: the money rotated *within* the market toward better trackers, the older dividend funds kept gaining holders, and that looks like investors getting smarter in a bull run, not losing faith in the manufactured wage.² The falsification test is clean — if high-dividend holdings snap back the next time the index corrects and people again crave "cash-flow security," then 2026 was cyclical performance-chasing and this thesis is wrong. Two honest caveats stand regardless: the eighteen-million figure counts holdings, not people; and whether a given month's payout is truly 吃老本 depends on the fund, so treat it as a contested critique, not a blanket fact.²

There is a warning in it for Singapore, too, which is why the desk files it here. The same forces — an aging population, a long habit of saving, a hunger for yield in a low-rate decade — run through this reader's own market, and the local love of high-dividend REITs and income funds rhymes with the 存股族's. The lesson is not "avoid income" but "know what the cheque is made of": whether a distribution is earnings paid out or capital handed back is the whole difference between a wage and 吃老本, and it is a difference a monthly rhythm is designed to blur.²

Either way, the tribe has learned something the West keeps having to relearn: a yield is not a wage, and a cheque you pay yourself is not the same as being paid. The FT will write this up in a month. You read it first.²

SOURCES 1 — Euromoney ("Sayonara Mrs Watanabe"), Bloomberg Opinion (27 May 2024, "My Search for the Original Mrs. Watanabe") — Japanese retail FX carry trade; ~US\$9.1bn/day by 2007 (-1/5 of Tokyo); 2008 unwind; retail leverage capped (50× 2010, 25× Aug 2011). 2 — bnext, ETtoday, AmCham Business Topics (Sep 2026) — rotation within the market; older dividend funds still gaining; generational split (held pending primary); the 18m-holdings caveat; 吃老本 as a contested critique. Argument is the desk's; facts sourced or held.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

A hundred books in, the pattern is plain: the things that keep are the ones made to. A plate outlives its pattern because someone fired it properly; a dram is worth the wait because a barrel did slow work on it; a mountain is worth the return because it will still be there, hiding and revealing, long after the queue for its photograph has gone home. Even the week's hard news was a lesson in the opposite — a strait closed by force, a rate lifted by nerve, a wage manufactured overnight in Taipei out of a monthly cheque that was partly one's own money coming back. Morris said to keep nothing that is neither useful nor beautiful. A hundred editions have been an argument that the two are usually the same thing, and that patience is how you tell. We counted what we could stand behind, and held the rest for tomorrow.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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